

D. The Diet Diary

1. Introduction

Introduce this phase of the interview carefully to ensure cooperation. All dietary survey techniques depend heavily on the motivation of the person under study.

Explain that data has already been collected on nearly all aspects of health and lifestyle, but that one further very important part - the diet - remains to be recorded. In order to obtain dietary information, it is necessary to write down details of every single item of food and drink consumed and to give some idea of the amount consumed. The aim of the survey is to learn about the survey member's usual dietary pattern so the record has to be made over several days.

2. General Method

Firstly you will ask the survey members to recall everything that they ate or drank over the preceeding two days.

This will not only provide us with very useful information but will also demonstrate how we would like it to be set out in the special booklet.

Then the survey members will be asked to use the same methods to continue the diary for the next five days. When the booklet is full, it will contain a full 7 days' dietary information and the survey members will be asked to post it back to use in the envelope provided.

3. The 48 hour Dietary Recall

Begin by calculating the start of the 48 hour period prior to the morning of the interview. Write in the day and date of these two days in the first two sections in the booklet. Record all foods, drinks, snacks and alcohol consumed in that period beginning with the question:

"What was the first thing you ate or drank onday?"

In order to describe the dietary intake we need to know what the food or drink was or what it was made from. We will then express it in terms of its constituent parts e.g. protein, polyunsaturated fats, carbohydrates, etc. To quantify these constituents it is essential that we know how much of the food or drink was consumed.

Refer to the first few pages of the diary. This sets out what we need to know about some common foods and drink and indicates the easiest measures to think of when recording the amounts. As you record the 48 hour history, use this reference, demonstrating to the survey member as you do so.

It is worth making sure that the survey member knows the difference between teaspoon, desertspoon and tablespoon and that a cup is a teacup (approx 8 fluid ounces.).

For some foods e.g. cheese, there is no handy measure. If weight cannot be estimated, use the term "helping" and say if it was large, medium or small.

At the end of each day, remind the survey member about snacks and beverages that are easily forgotten when thinking in terms of lunch, tea etc. Include here a discrete reminder about alcohol consumption and if not already recorded, put it in at the end of the relevant day section.

4. The Five Day Diet Record

Put in the days and dates of the next five days in each section of the booklet and ask the survey members if they would fill them in as you did for the preceeding two days. Say that it is best if they do so as they go along so they should keep the booklet with them all the time during the period.

Ask the survey members to post the booklet in the prepaid envelope to us in Bristol.